

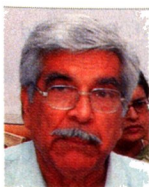


WATERLESS PIT: This dry well tells the story

THE GREAT DRY

IF YOU'VE TO PINPOINT GOVERNMENT neglect and failure, it is in the declining availability of water for irrigation. Even 60 years after Independence, 60 per cent of the farmlands are still dependent on good monsoons for reasonable crop productions. Efforts to increase the area under irrigation in the past decade have been an abysmal failure. Here are some revealing statistics. Between 1981 and 1991 the annual growth of land being brought under irrigation was 2.27 per cent. But between 1991 and 2004, that figure dropped to 1.15 per cent. In real terms, between 1985 and 1995, 14 lakh hectare were brought under irrigation. But between 1995 and 2005 that figure fell to 6.85 lakh hectare.

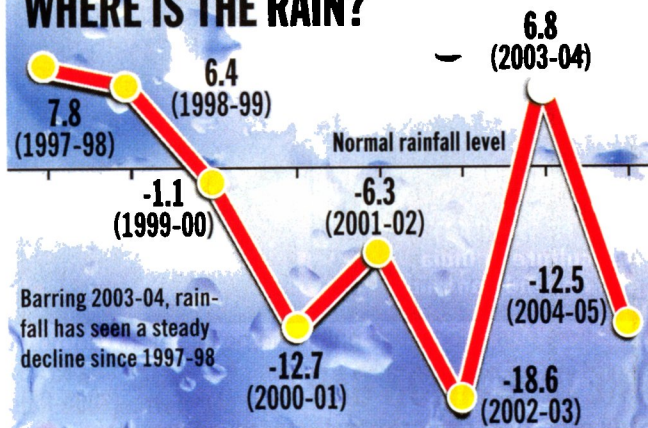
The reason is apparent—there was a major slow-up in investment in infrastructure for agriculture in the past decade. Public investment in irrigation has declined from 23



"We didn't understand the crisis of land and water till last year even though growth rates had flattened."

Y. K. ALAGH, FORMER UNION MINISTER

WHERE IS THE RAIN?



Figures in percentage

per cent of the total plan outlay in the First Plan period to about 5 per cent in the 10th Plan. In contrast, as Union Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar points out, investment in telecommunication sector averages 13 per cent of the GDP (see interview). Even the figure of 6.8 lakh hectare of additional land brought under irrigation during the past decade is disputed by the Planning Commission. It commented that the land use data shows no real increase in irrigated area. Strangely for the 10th Plan, while the target of spending Rs 90,000 crore towards investment in irrigation was met,